

SIMMERING DISCONTENT

Disgruntled by unfulfilled promises, Muslims show signs of drifting away from the ruling Congress and are willing to forge new alliances in their quest for security and a better life

Photographs by SHRIYA PATIL



■ **By Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai**

The Muslims of Maharashtra have declared jihad against the Democratic Front Government. As the list of unfulfilled promises grows long, the Congress-led state Government is finding it hard to keep its secular image intact. For years, the Muslims have been a dependable votebank for the party but as the state Government fails to deliver on one of its key promises—implementation of the Srikrishna Commission Report on the 1992-93 Mumbai riots—Muslims from across the state have cut across sectarian divides to put up a united front against Chief Minister Vilasrao Deshmukh.

The battle cry came on October 25,

when over 5,000 Muslims gathered at Azad Maidan to protest against the Government's shoddy approach to the commission's report. Organised by Nyay Andolan, an umbrella body that has brought together over 37 Muslim socio-religious organisations, the movement is being dubbed as the beginning of a war for justice. Explains Rais Shaikh, coordinator of the andolan and general secretary of welfare organisation Quami Majlis-e-Shura, "For the first time in Mumbai's history since Independence, all Muslim sects have come together to fight for a cause. We have found a new language to talk to the Congress."

While the controversial report is the immediate cause for the unrest, the latent anger is evident as the commu-

FEVER PITCH: The minority community is ready to declare war on the state Government

nity has been living on empty promises for decades now. From poor infrastructure and employment opportunities to not giving election tickets to Muslim candidates, the allegations are enough to expose the Congress's bias against them. "They are willing to give funds for pilgrimages to appease the community, but we want education and development," adds Shaikh.

It is the Congress's tendency to adopt manipulative tactics that has turned the Muslims against the party. Citing an example, Shaikh says, the andolan had warned the Government that failure to meet their demands and implementation of the commission's